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A PLANNER'S GUIDE TO NEGOTIATING AV

12 AV Concessions to Ask Before You Sign

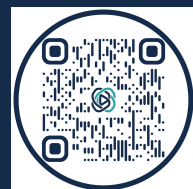
The AV quote is a starting point. Here is what experienced planners ask for, and how they ask.

WRITTEN FOR

Meeting and event professionals.

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SCAN TO CONNECT

Meeting planners negotiate room rates. They negotiate food and beverage minimums, attrition clauses, and parking. Then the audiovisual quote arrives, and many of them sign it as written.

That is a missed opportunity. AV pricing is among the most negotiable parts of any meeting budget, and that holds whether the provider is the hotel's in-house team or an outside production company. Providers have room to move. They move for planners who know what to ask for.

The catch is timing and precision. Concessions have to be requested by name, in writing, before the agreement is signed. After signature, the provider has no incentive to concede anything.

What follows is a working list of standard concessions, organized by category, along with guidance on how to make the ask.

CATEGORY ONE

Pricing concessions

Start with how the quote is built. Equipment, fees, and the length of the engagement all offer places to ask.

- ▶ **Multi-day rental discounts.** Ask how the quote prices equipment across the run of the show. On a multi-day meeting, the gear is delivered once, set once, and struck once. The rental pricing should reflect that. Do not expect a one-day rate, because the gear is unavailable to the provider for your whole event plus transit. A day or two off the rental is a reasonable ask, especially on lower-end equipment.
- ▶ **Load-in, rehearsal, and dark days.** Most meetings include days when the equipment is in the room but the audience is not: the day the crew loads in, the rehearsal day, a dark day between sessions. Ask for equipment charges on those days to be reduced or waived.
- ▶ **Service charges and production fees.** Read the bottom third of the quote as carefully as the top. Ask what each fee covers. Then ask for it to be reduced or capped. A planner who asks the question gets a clearer answer and often a better number.
- ▶ **Multi-year and multi-event pricing.** If you can commit to more than one meeting, say so, and ask for pricing that reflects the commitment. A provider will sharpen the number for business it can count on.
Ask for a performance clause alongside the discount. Most providers will agree to one, and it lets you exit the commitment if the service falls short.

CATEGORY TWO

Labor concessions

Labor is where AV budgets drift. The estimate looks reasonable in the proposal, then the invoice arrives with minimums, overtime, and penalties no one discussed. Hourly rates are generally non-negotiable, so spend your effort on what does move: how the call is built, and getting every rule on paper before you sign.

- ▶ **Minimums in writing.** Ask for the minimum call on every position in the quote. Traveling crew is typically on a 10-hour day rate, and local crew is generally on an 8-hour minimum. Certain positions in certain markets offer 4-hour minimums. Ask where a shorter minimum applies, especially for load-in and strike.
- ▶ **No new call for a short task.** A small job should not automatically add a technician at a full minimum. Ask whether someone already on the call can cover it by staying an hour or two later.
- ▶ **Premium rates and their triggers.** Overtime, meal penalties, and quick-turnaround charges are where the invoice outruns the estimate. Ask for each rate, and what triggers it, to be listed in the agreement. Then ask which ones your schedule is likely to hit and whether a schedule change avoids them.
- ▶ **Approval before overtime.** Ask that any overtime beyond the estimate be approved by you before it is worked. It is a simple term to add, and it keeps the decision in your hands.
- ▶ **A walk-through of the labor call.** Ask the provider to explain who is on the call and why. The right number of technicians depends on your quality expectations (perfection is expensive), the technical scope of your event, the local labor market, and the mix of traveling and local crew. [The Levers of Labor](#) covers each of those. Challenge the call, if for no other reason than to make sure it has been well thought out, and ask what trimming it would put at risk.

CATEGORY THREE

Equipment and service concessions

These asks add value to the show without adding to the invoice. They are routine requests, and they are far easier to get in the proposal stage than onsite.

- ▶ **Backup and spare equipment.** Always ask for spares to be included at no charge. Backup equipment protects the provider's work as much as it protects your meeting, and it should not appear as a line item. If a pop-up meeting needs that gear, expect to pay for it, but ask for a standard rate, not a last-minute premium.
- ▶ **Gear for the small rooms.** Providers regularly include support equipment at no charge: a computer or printer for the show office, a gobo (a projected logo or pattern) in the hallway,

gear for a VIP reception or a small registration area. Billed separately, these small charges add up. Ask for that gear to be complimentary.

- ▶ **Creative assets.** Many providers have creative capability in house. Ask for small creative assets such as a slide template, title slides for your presenters, or pre-recorded voiceovers as part of the package.

MAKING THE ASK

How to ask

The list is half of the work. How and when you ask determines what you get.

- ▶ **Negotiate before signing.** This is the number one rule. Once the agreement is executed, your leverage is gone.
- ▶ **Tie the ask to the size of the booking.** The number of show days, the total spend, and any multi-year commitment are your leverage. Bigger spend, bigger ask.
- ▶ **Get it in writing.** A verbal promise from a sales representative tends to disappear by the time the crew is running your show. If a concession is not in the agreement, do not count on it.
- ▶ **Bundle the ask.** Present your concessions as a single list instead of negotiating item by item. It is easier for a provider to say yes once than to say yes five separate times.
- ▶ **Know what costs the provider money.** Not all concessions are equal on the other side of the table. Adding a second confidence monitor costs the provider virtually nothing. Adding a camera requires a camera operator or a new switcher, and that is a real expense for them. Aim your asks at the first kind.
- ▶ **Use competition.** If you are comparing providers, tell each one. Make it clear you are reviewing the full offerings, not just the bottom line. A provider who knows the concessions are being weighed will put them on the table.

PUTTING IT TO WORK

The bottom line

None of these requests is unusual. Providers hear them regularly and grant them regularly. What separates the planners who get them from the planners who don't is not budget size or negotiating skill. It is the decision to ask, by name and in writing, before the agreement is signed.

Build the list once. Bring it to every meeting you plan.

The concessions checklist

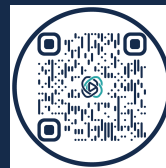
Twelve asks to bring to every AV agreement.

- 1 Discounted rates on multi-day equipment rentals
- 2 Reduced or waived rates for load-in, rehearsal, and dark days
- 3 Reduced or capped service charges and production fees
- 4 Multi-year or multi-event discount pricing
- 5 Minimum call for every position, in writing
- 6 No new minimum call for a short task
- 7 Premium rates and their triggers listed in the agreement
- 8 Your approval before any overtime is worked
- 9 A walk-through of the labor call and what trimming would put at risk
- 10 Backup or spare equipment at no charge, always
- 11 Complimentary gear for the show office, a VIP reception, and a small registration area
- 12 Creative assets: slide templates, title slides, and voiceovers

Want a second set of eyes on your AV quote?

Your AV Department is an independent AV production sourcing and advocacy service for association and corporate meeting planners. If you'd like a second set of eyes on a quote before you sign, send it over. There is no cost to you. We are paid by the supplier you choose, and we explain how that works at youravdept.com.

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